Preface

The collection housed at the Museum of Islamic Art, Cairo was established in 1881, when objects were first stored in the eastern arcade of the mosque of al-Hakim. As the collection grew, a small building was erected in the mosque's courtyard by 1892 to accommodate it, before the collection moved to its current location in 1903. Today, 145 years since its founding, it is considered the most important collection of Islamic art in the world, comprising over 100,000 objects. Yet the museum does not have the space to exhibit what it so proudly holds. The majority of the collection remains in storage; many pieces have never been seen by the public, and some have been kept from view for more than fifty years.

As students and practitioners of the arts and crafts, we take great pride and interest in our shared historical repertoire, and nowhere is that interest more keenly felt than in the field of woodwork. At NADIM, we believe that you can tell the story of a nation through its woodwork. Over the past two years, NADIM has worked closely with the Museum of Islamic Art to bring to light a body of woodwork that has remained in storage for decades. Curating, selecting, cataloguing, restoring, and finally displaying these varied objects has been a journey worth taking. The museum's restoration team managed the technical preservation and conservation of all the artefacts with great skill, while NADIM supplied the materials and resources required for what proved to be a meticulous and extended undertaking. Throughout this period, NADIM worked closely with the museum's management team, consulting records and archives to research the history of each object.

Once the 240 plus pieces that form this exhibition had been selected, finding an appropriate space in which to display them presented its own challenge: the collection ranges from monumental doors of considerable scale to objects as intimate and delicate as hair combs. The exhibition also draws on the museum's archive, which holds a remarkable collection of documents, photographs, glass slides, and even the original key to the museum's door. It was ultimately agreed to make use of the museum's large corridors and the storage area at the rear of the building, as well as the temporary exhibition hall near

the entrance, together adding four new exhibition spaces to an already full museum. Preparing and transforming these areas into proper exhibition halls, complete with display cases and appropriate lighting, presented a further challenge of its own.

Dedicating this space to woodwork represents a significant gain for visitors and scholars alike. It fills gaps that have long existed in the permanent collection and complements what is already on display. Through these objects - doors, mashrabeyas, ceilings, and even the most personal of everyday items - the life lived in Egypt over more than a thousand years can be told. It is our hope that this exhibition sheds light on pieces of great historical significance that have for too long remained in the dark, overcrowding storage facilities across Egyptian museums, unseen and understudied. Many thousands of hidden treasures remain in storage still.

Though 145 years have passed since this collection was founded, and 122 years since it came to its present home, we can only hope that the Museum of Islamic Art, Cairo continues to grow, in space, in ambition, and in its ability to share with the world the extraordinary heritage it holds.

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